The Tale of Benjamin Bunny

BY

BEATRIX POTTER



Retold for you by the

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Meet the characters



Benjamin

Peter's cousin



Peter Rabbit

a little rabbit



Old Mr. Bunny

Benjamin's father

Look at the pictures. What can you see?



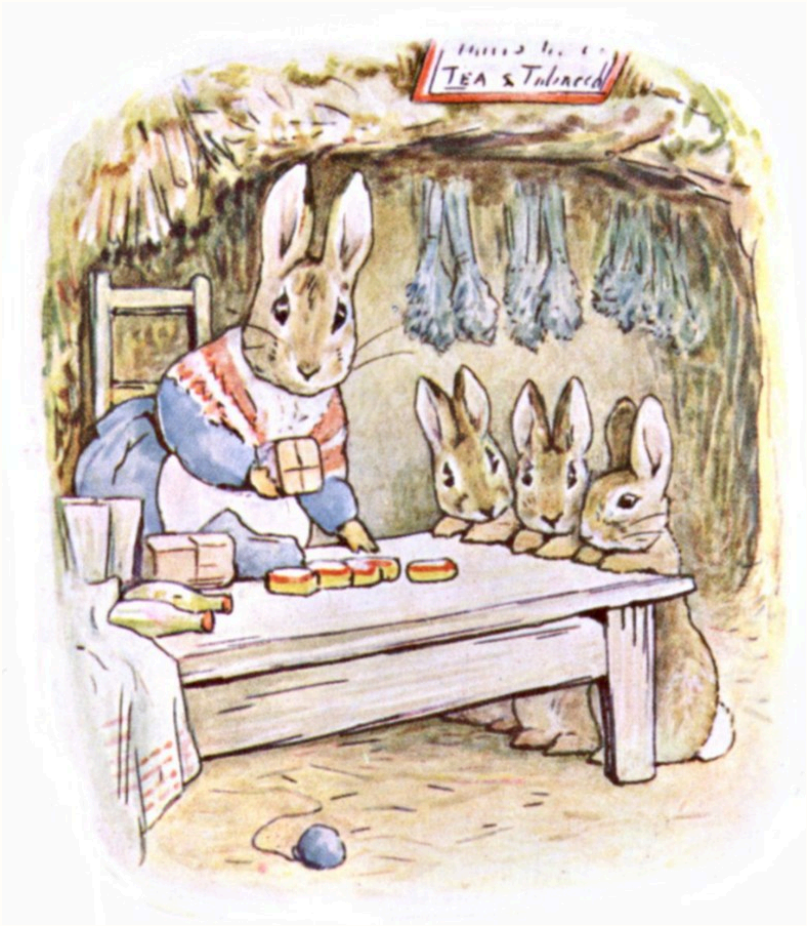
One morning, little **Benjamin Bunny** sits on a bank.

He hears a pony: trit-trot, trit-trot!

Mr. and Mrs. McGregor are going out.



Benjamin hops down the road.
Hop, skip and jump!



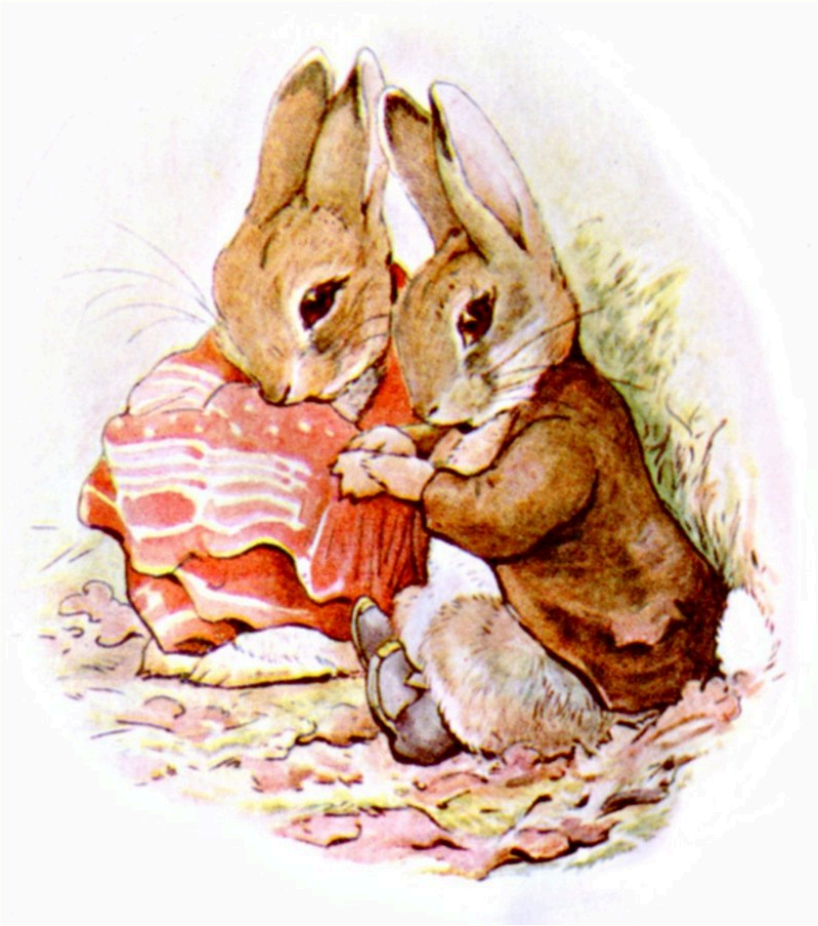
He goes to visit his cousin, **Peter Rabbit**.



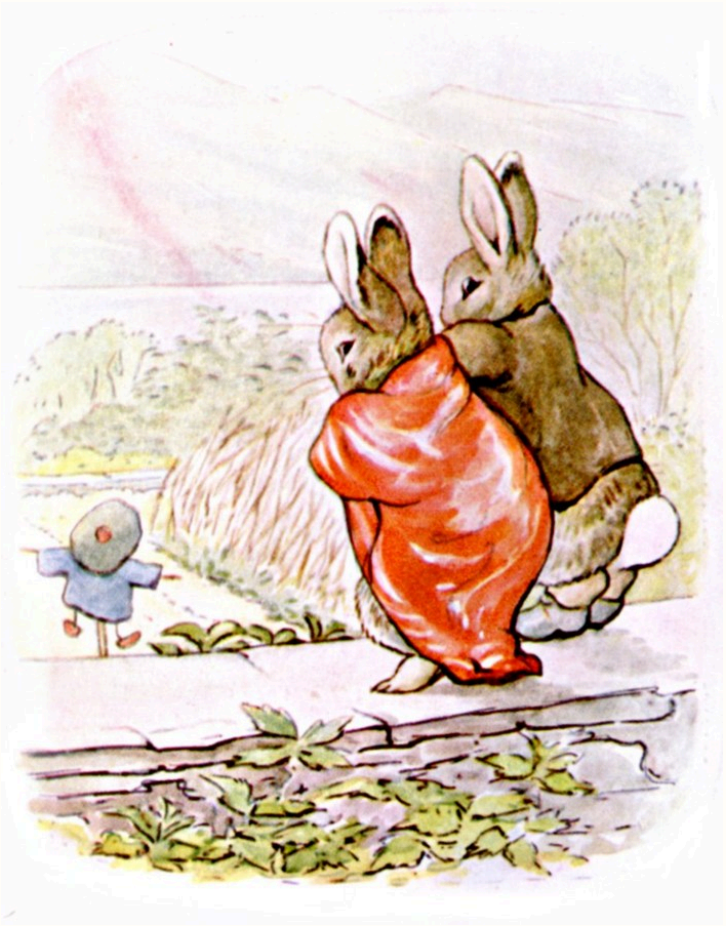
He finds Peter behind the big tree.



Peter looks sad.
He is wearing a red handkerchief.



“Where are your clothes?” asks Benjamin.
“On the scarecrow in Mr. McGregor’s garden,” says Peter.



The two little rabbits climb onto the garden wall.
They look down at the garden.



They climb down a pear tree.
Bump! Peter falls into the flower bed.



First, they get Peter's clothes back from the scarecrow.



Benjamin fills the handkerchief with onions.
They are a present for his aunt.



Benjamin eats a lettuce leaf. Crunch!
But Peter is scared. He wants to go home.



Peter drops some onions.



They walk past flower pots and tubs.
Peter hears funny noises.



Oh no!
A **big cat** is sitting round the corner!



The rabbits hide under a basket.
The cat comes and sniffs...
then she sits on top of the basket!



She sits there for **five hours**!
Peter and Benjamin are stuck in the dark.



Then — pitter-patter — someone is on the wall.
It is old Mr. Bunny, Benjamin's father!



Old Mr. Bunny jumps down.
He pushes the cat off the basket.



He locks the cat in the greenhouse.
Then he lifts up the basket.



He takes the onions
and marches the two little rabbits home.



Peter's mother is very happy.
Peter has his clothes and shoes again!



The End

Words to learn

Parole da imparare

cousin	cugino
pony	pony
wall	muro
pear tree	pero
clothes	vestiti
scarecrow	spaventapasseri
handkerchief	fazzoletto
onion	cipolla
lettuce	lattuga
basket	cesto
cat	gatto
greenhouse	serra
scared	spaventato
happy	felice

Let’s talk!

Answer the questions · Rispondi alle domande

1. Who is Benjamin’s cousin?
2. Where are Peter’s clothes?
3. What does Benjamin put in the handkerchief?
4. Where do the rabbits hide?
5. How long does the cat sit on the basket?
6. Who saves the rabbits?

Your turn

- Draw your favourite picture from the story and tell the class about it.
- Act out the story with your friends!

The original story

Beatrix Potter, 1904 · for parents and older readers

AUTHOR OF "THE TAIL OF PETER RABBIT," &C.

NEW YORK

FOR THE CHILDREN OF SAWREY

FROM

OLD MR. BUNNY

One morning a little rabbit sat on a bank.

He pricked his ears and listened to the trit-trot, trit-trot of a pony.

A gig was coming along the road; it was driven by Mr. McGregor, and beside him sat Mrs. McGregor in her best bonnet.

As soon as they had passed, little Benjamin Bunny slid down into the road, and set off—with a hop, skip, and a jump—to call upon his relations, who lived in the wood at the back of Mr. McGregor's garden.

That wood was full of rabbit holes; and in the neatest, sandiest hole of all lived Benjamin's aunt and his cousins—Flopsy, Mopsy, Cotton-tail, and Peter.

Old Mrs. Rabbit was a widow; she earned her living by knitting rabbit-wool mittens and muffatees (I once bought a pair at a bazaar). She also sold herbs, and rosemary tea, and rabbit-tobacco (which is what we call lavender).

Little Benjamin did not very much want to see his Aunt.

He came round the back of the fir-tree, and nearly tumbled upon the top of his Cousin Peter.

Peter was sitting by himself. He looked poorly, and was dressed in a red cotton pocket-handkerchief.

"Peter," said little Benjamin, in a whisper, "who has got your clothes?"

Peter replied, "The scarecrow in Mr. McGregor's garden," and described how he had been chased about the garden, and had dropped his shoes and coat.

Little Benjamin sat down beside his cousin and assured him that Mr. McGregor had gone out in a gig, and Mrs. McGregor also; and certainly for the day, because she was wearing her best bonnet.

Peter said he hoped that it would rain.

At this point old Mrs. Rabbit's voice was heard inside the rabbit hole, calling: "Cotton-tail! Cotton-tail! fetch some more camomile!"

Peter said he thought he might feel better if he went for a walk.

They went away hand in hand, and got upon the flat top of the wall at the bottom of the wood. From here they looked down into Mr. McGregor's garden. Peter's coat and shoes were plainly to be seen upon the scarecrow, topped with an old tam-o'-shanter of Mr. McGregor's.

Little Benjamin said: "It spoils people's clothes to squeeze under a gate; the proper way to get in is to climb down a pear-tree."

Peter fell down head first; but it was of no consequence, as the bed below was newly raked and quite soft.

It had been sown with lettuces.

They left a great many odd little footmarks all over the bed, especially little Benjamin, who was wearing clogs.

Little Benjamin said that the first thing to be done was to get back Peter's clothes, in order that they might be able to use the pocket-handkerchief.

They took them off the scarecrow. There had been rain during the night; there was water in the shoes, and the coat was somewhat shrunk.

Benjamin tried on the tam-o'-shanter, but it was too big for him.

Then he suggested that they should fill the pocket-handkerchief with onions, as a little present for his Aunt.

Peter did not seem to be enjoying himself; he kept hearing noises.

Benjamin, on the contrary, was perfectly at home, and ate a lettuce leaf. He said that he was in the habit of coming to the garden with his father to get lettuces for their Sunday dinner.

(The name of little Benjamin's papa was old Mr. Benjamin Bunny.)

The lettuces certainly were very fine.

Peter did not eat anything; he said he should like to go home. Presently he dropped half the onions.

Little Benjamin said that it was not possible to get back up the pear-tree with a load of vegetables. He led the way boldly towards the other end of the garden. They went along a little walk on planks, under a sunny, red brick wall.

The mice sat on their doorsteps cracking cherry-stones; they winked at Peter Rabbit and little Benjamin Bunny.

Presently Peter let the pocket-handkerchief go again.

They got amongst flower-pots, and frames, and tubs. Peter heard noises worse than ever; his eyes were as big as lolly-pops!

He was a step or two in front of his cousin when he suddenly stopped.

This is what those little rabbits saw round that corner!

Little Benjamin took one look, and then, in half a minute less than no time, he hid himself and Peter and the onions underneath a large basket....

The cat got up and stretched herself, and came and sniffed at the basket.

Perhaps she liked the smell of onions!

Anyway, she sat down upon the top of the basket.

She sat there for five hours.

I cannot draw you a picture of Peter and Benjamin underneath the basket, because it was quite dark, and because the smell of onions was fearful; it made Peter Rabbit and little Benjamin cry.

The sun got round behind the wood, and it was quite late in the afternoon; but still the cat sat upon the basket.

At length there was a pitter-patter, pitter-patter, and some bits of mortar fell from the wall above.

The cat looked up and saw old Mr. Benjamin Bunny prancing along the top of the wall of the upper terrace.

He was smoking a pipe of rabbit-tobacco, and had a little switch in his hand.

He was looking for his son.

Old Mr. Bunny had no opinion whatever of cats.

He took a tremendous jump off the top of the wall on to the top of the cat, and cuffed it off the basket, and kicked it into the greenhouse, scratching off a handful of fur.

The cat was too much surprised to scratch back.

When old Mr. Bunny had driven the cat into the greenhouse, he locked the door.

Then he came back to the basket and took out his son Benjamin by the ears, and whipped him with the little switch.

Then he took out his nephew Peter.

Then he took out the handkerchief of onions, and marched out of the garden.

When Mr. McGregor returned about half an hour later he observed several things which perplexed him.

It looked as though some person had been walking all over the garden in a pair of clogs—only the footmarks were too ridiculously little!

Also he could not understand how the cat could have managed to shut herself up inside the greenhouse, locking the door upon the outside.

When Peter got home his mother forgave him, because she was so glad to see that he had found his shoes and coat. Cotton-tail and Peter folded up the pocket-handkerchief, and old Mrs. Rabbit strung up the onions and hung them from the kitchen ceiling, with the bunches of herbs and the rabbit-tobacco.

About this book

The Tale of Benjamin Bunny is written and illustrated by Beatrix Potter (1866–1943). It was first published in 1904. The original text and illustrations are in the **public domain**: the author and illustrator died more than 70 years ago, so they are free for everyone to read and share (Italian Law no. 633/1941, art. 25; EU Directive 2006/116/EC).

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